

The Long LAST MILE

The Manmohan Singh Government has plenty more Olympian hurdles to cross before the nuke deal can be operationalised

■ By Raj Chengappa

If Prakash Karat is to be believed then all India has to do is successfully negotiate a safeguards agreement with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) after which the "notorious" Indo-US nuclear deal would be on auto-pilot as far as the country is concerned. But for Prime Minister Manmohan Singh and his government, the flight ahead is not going to be as comfortable as the CPI (M) general secretary makes it out to be. The trust vote in Parliament is an Olympian challenge in itself but Manmohan would have to perform many more such feats before India's path-breaking civilian nuclear deal with the US becomes operationalised.

The Left's stringent objections and delaying tactics have left both the Indian and the US governments with little elbow room to consummate the deal during US President George

Bush's tenure which ends in January 2009. Apart from the IAEA Board clearing the India-specific safeguards agreement, the Nuclear Suppliers Group (NSG) has to agree to make an exception in its rules that would permit its 45 members to carry out civilian nuclear trade with India even though it is not a signatory to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT). After that the US President will make a determination that India has fulfilled its part of the deal and send it to the US Congress which will then have to take an up-or-down vote on it.

Only after all these processes are completed to everyone's satisfaction, will the deal become operationalised and allow India to engage in nuclear trade with American entities. If Manmohan suddenly seemed in a hurry to push the deal through, it was because any further delay would mean that India would have to negotiate with a new President and a new Congress to seal the deal. And there was every danger that they may not be as responsive or enthusiastic as Bush and the current legislators are. Also the G8 Summit in Toyako, Japan, was an ideal place for Manmohan to canvass for the deal with not only Bush but other leaders belonging to NSG countries including China.

Judging from the unequivocal endorsement he got from the G8 countries as also from China, indicating that it would not be an obstacle at the NSG, the gamble was well worth the effort. In his 50-minute meeting with Bush, the prime minister also got assurances that the US President

KARAT HAD NOT DONE his homework. The IAEA safeguards do not kick in till the NSG and the US Congress clear the deal and India operationalises it



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